up your mind. That's not a lot of time to weigh up your options, which are normally 'should I stand up and hit, or should I duck?' So, from that point of view, it was quite frightening to face him.

And it was no less pleasant getting hit by him. Shoaib hit me in the chest once during our tour to Pakistan in 2003. It was the first ball during one of the ODI games – he tried to bounce me, but the ball didn't get up. I just sort of dropped my hands, and the ball klapped me on the chest and ran down to third man. It hit me really, really hard, and that was only a glancing blow, because I was standing fairly side-on.

As I mentioned earlier, those huge in-swingers that zero in on your toes are equally intimidating. I'll never forget that 2003 Test in Lahore, when Shoaib nailed Gary on the cheek. Shoaib was bowling around the wicket, and he pitched one in short and Gary tried to hook him … but he got smacked right in the face. Ten stitches, and a broken eye socket and nose later … Check it on YouTube. Frightening.

Gary showed huge courage to return in the second innings and score a gutsy 46 to help us try to save the Test. It wasn't enough, unfortunately. Back to the story, though – Gary leaves the field, blood pouring from his face, and in comes Neil McKenzie. It might have been the very next ball, but Neil gets a huge reverse-swinger straight on the toe. I mean, the ball bent like a bladdy banana. The direct hit didn't break Neil's toe, but he was out lbw, and he could hardly walk for the rest of the day. Proteas bowling coach Vincent Barnes still reckons it was the best spell of fast bowling he's ever seen.

I've got to know Shoaib a little better, having played quite a few games with him for the Lashings World XI, and let me tell you, he is just as wild off the field as he is on it.